

Forensic Cheiloscopy: An Advanced Computational Framework for Automated Lip-Print Pattern Analysis and Person Identification Using MobileViT-S

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Abstract—Lip prints are considered a valuable biometric cue in forensic investigations, yet practical identification is challenging due to limited availability of reference lip prints. The proposed system is motivated by the need for an assistive tool that can prioritize suspects when only facial photographs are available. The concept focuses on estimating the likelihood of association between a crime scene lip print and lip regions extracted from suspect images. The implementation uses image preprocessing, lip region detection from facial photographs, and a shared deep learning encoder based on MobileViT to extract discriminative embeddings. Similarity between embeddings is computed using a metric learning approach to rank suspects according to likelihood scores. Experimental observations indicate that the system can effectively highlight probable suspects even under low-quality image conditions. The main advantage lies in its applicability to real-world forensic scenarios with constrained data, while a key limitation is that facial lip regions do not contain true cheiloscopic patterns, restricting the system to assistive rather than definitive identification.

Index Terms—

I. INTRODUCTION

Biometric authentication systems have become a cornerstone of modern security, surveillance, and forensic identification due to the growing demand for accurate, reliable, and user-friendly identity verification mechanisms. Unlike conventional knowledge-based or token-based security methods, biometric systems rely on intrinsic physiological or behavioral characteristics, making them inherently more resistant to loss, theft, or unauthorized sharing. Widely adopted biometric modalities such as fingerprints, facial features, iris patterns, and voice signals have achieved significant commercial and forensic success. However, these traditional traits are not without limitations. Issues such as spoofing attacks, environmental sensitivity, partial occlusion, aging effects, and privacy concerns continue to challenge their robustness and long-term reliability, particularly in unconstrained real-world scenarios.

In response to these limitations, alternative biometric traits have gained increasing research attention. Cheiloscopy, the scientific study of lip print patterns, has emerged as a promising yet relatively underexplored biometric modality. Lip prints are formed by the grooves and wrinkles present on the labial mucosa and are widely considered unique to each individual,

even among identical twins. Moreover, lip print morphology remains largely stable over time and is comparatively difficult to forge, making it suitable for both biometric authentication and forensic investigations. Lip prints are frequently encountered at crime scenes on objects such as glasses, cups, cigarettes, envelopes, and tissues, further highlighting their forensic significance. Despite these advantages, automated cheiloscopic recognition remains a challenging problem due to variations in illumination, pose, facial expression, image degradation, and the limited availability of large-scale standardized datasets.

Recent advances in deep learning have significantly transformed biometric recognition by enabling automatic hierarchical feature learning directly from raw imagery. Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) have demonstrated strong capability in extracting local texture patterns, which are essential for analyzing fine-grained biometric traits such as lip grooves and sulci structures. However, purely CNN-based approaches often struggle to model long-range spatial dependencies and global contextual relationships, especially when dealing with complex and irregular anatomical textures. To address these shortcomings, transformer-based vision architectures have been introduced, leveraging self-attention mechanisms to capture global feature interactions. Nevertheless, pure Vision Transformers typically require large training datasets and substantial computational resources, limiting their practicality for lightweight forensic deployments.

To bridge this gap, hybrid architectures such as Mobile Vision Transformers (MobileViT) have been proposed, combining the locality modeling strength of CNNs with the global reasoning capability of transformers in a computationally efficient framework. MobileViT integrates convolutional layers for fine-scale spatial encoding with transformer blocks for long-range contextual modeling, achieving an effective balance between representational power and efficiency. This architectural synergy makes MobileViT particularly well suited for biometric applications where both discriminative accuracy and real-time feasibility are critical.

Complementing the backbone architecture, Siamese neural networks have proven highly effective for biometric verification tasks through deep metric learning. Unlike traditional closed-set classifiers, Siamese networks learn an embedding

space in which samples from the same identity are pulled closer together while samples from different identities are pushed apart. This pairwise learning paradigm is especially advantageous in forensic settings, where the system must often operate in open-set conditions and perform ranking-based identification rather than fixed-class classification.

In this work, we propose a Siamese MobileViT-based cheiloscopy recognition framework designed to address the core challenges of automated lip print analysis. The proposed pipeline consists of multiple tightly integrated stages, including:

- precise lip region extraction using facial landmark detection,
- contrast-enhanced preprocessing to improve ridge visibility,
- extensive stochastic data augmentation to mitigate dataset scarcity,
- pairwise deep metric learning using a Siamese architecture.

A weight-shared MobileViT encoder is employed to learn compact and highly discriminative embeddings for both latent lip prints and photographic lip regions. Similarity between samples is computed through distance-based comparison in the learned embedding manifold, enabling robust verification and scalable suspect ranking. The system is evaluated using both verification metrics and ranking-based biometric measures, demonstrating strong capability in learning modality-invariant cheiloscopic representations.

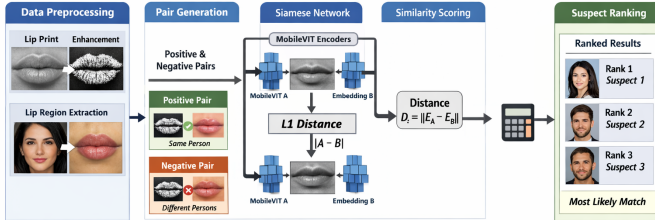


Fig. 1. Proposed Siamese MobileViT-based automated cheiloscopy framework illustrating preprocessing, pair generation, embedding extraction, similarity computation, and suspect ranking pipeline.

Furthermore, the modular design of the proposed framework ensures strong scalability and adaptability across diverse forensic scenarios and demographic distributions. In practical cheiloscopy, lip morphology can vary due to age progression, muscular deformation, cosmetic factors, and minor pathological conditions. The proposed deep metric learning formulation is inherently robust to such variations because it focuses on identity-invariant structural cues rather than superficial appearance alone.

A particularly important advantage of the Siamese formulation is its open-set capability. Unlike conventional classification systems that require retraining when new identities are added, the proposed framework supports dynamic enrollment. New subjects can be incorporated into the database by simply computing their 128-dimensional embeddings, enabling seamless scalability for evolving law-enforcement repositories. This property is critical for real-world forensic deployments where the gallery population is continuously expanding.

Additionally, the cross-modal nature of the proposed system directly addresses the practical forensic scenario in which a latent lip impression recovered from a crime scene must be matched against a photographic facial database rather than another clean lip print. The integration of MediaPipe-based landmark refinement improves robustness against pose variation and facial expression changes, which are common in unconstrained image acquisition. By transforming heterogeneous inputs into a unified discriminative hyperspace, the system effectively mitigates the long-standing modality gap in automated cheiloscopy.

Ultimately, the proposed framework moves automated lip print analysis closer to operational forensic readiness by providing an objective, scalable, and high-speed alternative to traditional manual examination. By combining hybrid CNN–Transformer representation learning with Siamese metric optimization, this work contributes toward the development of scientifically grounded, legally defensible, and practically deployable next-generation biometric identification systems.

II. RELATED WORKS

A. Lip Print–Based Biometric Recognition

Lip print analysis, commonly referred to as cheiloscopy, has long been investigated as a supplementary biometric modality due to the individuality and relative permanence of lip groove patterns. Early studies in this domain primarily relied on manual examination performed by forensic experts, where lip grooves were categorized into predefined morphological types. Although these manual methods established the forensic relevance of lip prints, they were inherently subjective, time-consuming, and difficult to scale for large databases.

Subsequent research introduced handcrafted feature extraction techniques such as edge detection, texture descriptors (e.g., Local Binary Patterns), Gabor filtering, and morphological analysis to automate portions of the recognition process. While these approaches demonstrated the feasibility of automated lip print identification, their performance remained sensitive to noise, illumination changes, and variations in image acquisition conditions. Moreover, handcrafted pipelines often struggled to generalize across datasets and required careful parameter tuning.

With the growing availability of digital imaging, statistical pattern recognition and classical machine learning methods were explored to improve repeatability and objectivity. However, these systems were still constrained by limited feature expressiveness and insufficient robustness under real forensic conditions. Consequently, achieving reliable, fully automated

lip-based biometric recognition has remained an open research challenge.

B. Deep Learning Approaches for Cheiloscopy

The emergence of deep learning has significantly advanced biometric recognition by enabling end-to-end hierarchical feature learning directly from raw images. Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) have been widely adopted in biometric applications due to their strong ability to capture local spatial patterns. In the context of cheiloscopy, CNN-based models have shown improved performance compared to handcrafted feature methods by automatically learning discriminative representations of lip groove textures.

Several studies have reported encouraging results using deep CNN architectures for lip print classification and verification tasks. These approaches demonstrated increased robustness to moderate variations in illumination, scale, and imaging noise. However, most existing works frame the problem as a closed-set classification task, which assumes that all identities are known during training. This assumption limits practical forensic applicability, where systems must often operate in open-set conditions and perform similarity-based matching.

Additionally, purely convolutional architectures are inherently local in their receptive fields and may struggle to capture long-range structural dependencies present in complex lip groove patterns. This limitation becomes particularly significant in forensic scenarios involving partial, smudged, or low-quality lip impressions. These challenges motivate the exploration of more expressive architectures capable of jointly modeling fine-grained local textures and global contextual relationships.

C. Siamese Networks and Metric Learning for Biometric Verification

Siamese neural networks have emerged as a powerful framework for biometric verification through deep metric learning. Instead of directly predicting identity classes, Siamese architectures learn an embedding space in which samples from the same individual are mapped closer together while samples from different individuals are pushed farther apart. This paradigm is especially effective in low-sample, one-shot, and open-set recognition scenarios.

Siamese-based approaches have achieved strong performance in several biometric domains, including fingerprint matching, face verification, and iris recognition [?], [?]. Their ability to generalize to unseen identities makes them particularly attractive for forensic applications. In the context of lip-based biometrics, Siamese learning enables direct pairwise comparison between latent lip prints and lip regions extracted from facial imagery, reducing dependence on large labeled identity datasets.

Nevertheless, the effectiveness of Siamese systems is highly dependent on the representational strength of the backbone encoder. Many earlier implementations relied on conventional CNN backbones, which, while effective for local texture modeling, may not fully capture the complex global morphology

of lip structures. This observation motivates the integration of hybrid architectures that can enhance embedding discriminability.

D. Lightweight Transformer-Based Models for Biometric Recognition

Transformer-based vision models have recently gained prominence due to their capability to model long-range dependencies through self-attention mechanisms. Vision Transformers (ViTs) have demonstrated strong performance across various visual recognition tasks. However, their high computational cost and large data requirements often limit their deployment in real-time or resource-constrained biometric systems.

To address these limitations, hybrid architectures such as Mobile Vision Transformers (MobileViT) have been proposed [?]. MobileViT combines convolutional layers for efficient local feature extraction with lightweight transformer blocks for global context modeling. This design achieves an effective trade-off between accuracy, model size, and computational efficiency, making it suitable for mobile and embedded vision applications.

Despite the growing success of MobileViT in general computer vision tasks, its application to cheiloscopic biometric recognition remains relatively underexplored in the literature. Integrating MobileViT within a Siamese metric learning framework offers a promising direction, as it enables simultaneous modeling of fine lip texture details and broader structural relationships while maintaining real-time feasibility.

E. Research Gap and Motivation

From the reviewed literature, three key gaps can be identified:

- Most existing cheiloscopy systems rely either on handcrafted features or CNN-only backbones, limiting their ability to capture global lip morphology.
- Many deep learning approaches are formulated as closed-set classifiers, which are not well suited for open-set forensic identification.
- Lightweight hybrid transformer models have not been sufficiently explored for cross-modal lip print matching.

To address these limitations, the present work proposes a Siamese MobileViT-based framework that combines hybrid local-global feature learning with deep metric optimization. The proposed approach is designed specifically for cross-modal cheiloscopic matching and scalable forensic deployment.

III. ARCHITECTURE

The proposed framework presents a cross-modal biometric verification system tailored for automated forensic cheiloscopy. In contrast to conventional identity classification systems that operate under a closed-set assumption, the proposed method adopts a Siamese network paradigm to model the problem as a deep metric learning task. This formulation enables the system to learn similarity relationships between heterogeneous inputs rather than relying on fixed class labels.

Specifically, the framework is designed to project two different modalities—latent lip prints obtained from forensic evidence and lip regions extracted from facial imagery—into a shared, discriminative embedding space. By enforcing weight sharing between the twin encoder branches, the network learns modality-invariant representations that preserve identity-specific morphological characteristics of the lip grooves while suppressing modality-dependent variations such as color differences, illumination changes, and capture noise.

The overall architecture consists of four principal stages: (i) data preprocessing and lip region extraction, (ii) pair generation with augmentation, (iii) Siamese feature encoding using a MobileViT-based backbone, and (iv) similarity computation and ranking-based decision making. This modular design ensures scalability, computational efficiency, and suitability for real-world forensic deployment where open-set identification and cross-modal matching are required.

A. Data Pre-processing and ROI Standardization

To minimize intra-class variance and suppress environmental noise, the proposed system employs two specialized preprocessing pipelines corresponding to the two Siamese input streams.

- 1) **Lip Region Extraction (Stream A):** The facial image is processed using the MediaPipe Face Mesh module to obtain dense facial landmarks. From the detected 468 landmarks, a predefined subset of lip boundary points is selected to localize the vermilion region. A tight bounding box is computed around these landmarks, after which the lip region is cropped and resized to 224×224 pixels. This step ensures spatial consistency and removes irrelevant facial background.
- 2) **Latent Print Enhancement (Stream B):** Forensic lip prints frequently exhibit poor contrast and acquisition noise. To enhance ridge–valley visibility, Contrast Limited Adaptive Histogram Equalization (CLAHE) is applied in the grayscale domain. The enhanced image is subsequently smoothed using Gaussian filtering ($k = 5$) to suppress high-frequency noise while preserving structural continuity.

The preprocessing stage is explicitly designed to address both inter-subject variability and acquisition-induced distortions commonly observed in forensic environments. In practical crime scene scenarios, lip impressions may suffer from smudging, partial deformation, uneven illumination, and background contamination. Accordingly, this module pursues two primary objectives: (i) maximization of discriminative ridge–valley contrast and (ii) enforcement of geometric consistency across samples.

For the facial stream, landmark-driven localization provides anatomically consistent cropping across subjects. Unlike naive rectangular cropping, the use of landmark coordinates preserves the proportional spatial relationship between the upper and lower lips. This geometric normalization significantly reduces intra-class variance caused by pose changes, facial scale differences, and minor expression variations.

For the latent print stream, adaptive histogram equalization enhances micro-textural contrast without excessive noise amplification. In contrast to global histogram equalization, CLAHE operates on localized tiles, preventing saturation artifacts and preserving subtle groove bifurcations that are critical for cheiloscopy discrimination. The subsequent Gaussian smoothing step further attenuates acquisition noise while maintaining ridge continuity.

Finally, both streams undergo intensity normalization to the range $[0, 1]$ and spatial resizing to 224×224 pixels. This standardization ensures compatibility with the MobileViT encoder while retaining sufficient spatial resolution for fine-grained biometric feature extraction.

B. MobileViT: Hybrid Feature Extraction

The core feature extractor in each Siamese branch is the MobileViT-S encoder. The selection of this architecture is motivated by the intrinsic structural characteristics of lip-print morphology. Cheiloscopy patterns simultaneously exhibit:

- fine-grained local textural structures (e.g., grooves and Type I–V patterns), and
- broader global morphological organization (overall lip contour and spatial groove distribution).

Conventional convolutional neural networks (CNNs) are highly effective at capturing localized texture through limited receptive fields but often struggle to model long-range spatial dependencies. MobileViT mitigates this limitation by integrating lightweight self-attention within a convolutional framework, enabling global context modeling while preserving computational efficiency suitable for mobile-scale deployment.

A typical MobileViT block performs three sequential operations:

- 1) **Local Representation:** A convolutional layer with kernel size $n \times n$ extracts localized spatial features and produces an intermediate feature map.
- 2) **Global Representation:** The feature map is unfolded into non-overlapping patches and reshaped into a token sequence. A stack of Transformer layers (L blocks) then models long-range dependencies among patches via self-attention.
- 3) **Feature Fusion:** The globally refined features are folded back to the spatial domain, concatenated with the local representation, and projected to the original channel dimension.

The choice of MobileViT-S is particularly well aligned with the morphological complexity of lip prints. Cheiloscopy grooves often form irregular, branching, and intersecting structures that span spatially distant regions. Effective discrimination therefore requires simultaneous modeling of micro-texture and global spatial arrangement.

Within the encoder, convolutional layers first generate feature maps

$$\mathbf{F} \in \mathbb{R}^{H' \times W' \times C},$$

which are subsequently reshaped into a sequence of patch embeddings:

$$\mathbf{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{N \times d} \quad (1)$$

where N denotes the number of patches and d represents the embedding dimension.

Global contextual relationships are then modeled using multi-head self-attention:

$$\text{Attention}(\mathbf{Q}, \mathbf{K}, \mathbf{V}) = \text{softmax} \left(\frac{\mathbf{Q}\mathbf{K}^T}{\sqrt{d_k}} \right) \mathbf{V} \quad (2)$$

This hybrid convolution–transformer design preserves the efficiency of CNN-based feature extraction while enhancing the network’s capacity to capture long-range structural dependencies. Consequently, the MobileViT-S encoder learns discriminative embeddings that jointly encode fine groove textures and holistic lip morphology, which is critical for reliable cross-modal cheiloscopy matching.

C. Siamese Metric Learning Framework

Let x_{print} and x_{face} denote the paired input images corresponding to a latent lip print and a facial lip region, respectively. Both inputs are processed through a weight-shared encoder $f_{\theta}(\cdot)$. Weight sharing ensures that identical transformations are applied to both modalities, encouraging the network to learn modality-invariant representations rather than modality-specific features.

The encoder produces d -dimensional identity embeddings:

$$\mathbf{h}_p = f_{\theta}(x_{\text{print}}), \quad \mathbf{h}_f = f_{\theta}(x_{\text{face}}) \quad (3)$$

where $\mathbf{h}_p, \mathbf{h}_f \in \mathbb{R}^{128}$.

Unlike conventional softmax-based classifiers, which are limited to a fixed set of enrolled identities, the Siamese formulation learns a generalized embedding function capable of comparing previously unseen individuals. This property is particularly important in forensic applications, where probe identities may not be present during training.

The shared-weight constraint enforces parameter consistency:

$$f_{\theta}^{(A)} = f_{\theta}^{(B)} \quad (4)$$

thereby projecting both modalities into a common latent space. The geometric objective of the embedding space is to minimize intra-class distance while maximizing inter-class separation:

$$\|\mathbf{h}_p - \mathbf{h}_f\|_2 \rightarrow 0 \quad (\text{same identity}) \quad (5)$$

$$\|\mathbf{h}_p - \mathbf{h}_f\|_2 \rightarrow \text{large} \quad (\text{different identities}) \quad (6)$$

This formulation converts identity verification into a metric-learning problem rather than a closed-set classification task.

1) *Distance Metric and Verification Head*: To quantify similarity between the two embeddings, the framework computes the element-wise absolute difference (L1 distance):

$$\mathbf{D}(\mathbf{h}_p, \mathbf{h}_f) = |\mathbf{h}_p - \mathbf{h}_f| \quad (7)$$

The resulting distance vector is passed to a verification head that produces a binary match probability $\hat{y}$. The head consists of a learnable projection followed by a sigmoid activation:

$$\hat{y} = \sigma(\mathbf{W}\mathbf{D} + b) = \frac{1}{1 + e^{-(\mathbf{W}\mathbf{D} + b)}} \quad (8)$$

The use of L1 distance improves robustness to small embedding perturbations and promotes sparse difference representations. Compared to L2 distance, the L1 formulation penalizes deviations linearly and reduces the influence of large outlier dimensions.

The learnable verification head acts as an adaptive similarity estimator. Instead of relying on a fixed distance threshold, the projection matrix $\mathbf{W}$ automatically assigns importance to embedding dimensions based on their discriminative relevance during training.

2) *Objective Function*: The network is optimized using the Binary Cross-Entropy (BCE) loss:

$$\mathcal{L} = -\frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N [y_i \log(\hat{y}_i) + (1 - y_i) \log(1 - \hat{y}_i)] \quad (9)$$

where $y_i \in \{0, 1\}$ denotes the ground-truth label for the i -th pair.

BCE loss is selected due to its probabilistic interpretation and stable gradient behavior in binary verification settings. The loss penalizes high-confidence errors more strongly, encouraging well-calibrated similarity predictions.

To improve generalization, the training process employs balanced positive and negative pairs, mitigating class imbalance. In addition, data augmentation during pair generation introduces controlled rotational, translational, and minor geometric variations, enhancing robustness to real-world acquisition variability.

D. Embedding-Based Ranking and Forensic Retrieval

Beyond binary verification, the learned embedding space enables ranking-based identification. Given a query embedding $\mathbf{h}_q$ and a gallery of stored embeddings $\{\mathbf{h}_i\}_{i=1}^M$, similarity is computed as:

$$D_i = \|\mathbf{h}_q - \mathbf{h}_i\|_2 \quad (10)$$

The system ranks identities in ascending order of D_i . The Rank-1 accuracy measures the proportion of queries whose closest match corresponds to the correct identity.

This retrieval-based formulation aligns with practical forensic workflows, where investigators compare a latent crime-scene print against a database of suspects and analyze ranked similarity results rather than relying solely on binary match outputs.

E. System Schematic

To consolidate the theoretical formulation and architectural components discussed above, the complete operational workflow of the proposed framework is illustrated through a unified system schematic. The diagram presents a dual-stream processing architecture in which heterogeneous biometric inputs are independently standardized and subsequently projected into a shared embedding space through a weight-coupled encoder.

The schematic highlights the strict symmetry imposed by the Siamese design. Both the latent lip print and the facial lip-region image undergo domain-specific preprocessing before entering the shared MobileViT encoder. The encoder operates as a common transformation function, ensuring that feature representations from both modalities reside within the same geometric embedding manifold. This structural symmetry is fundamental to enabling modality-invariant identity comparison.

Furthermore, the diagram clarifies the transition from representation learning to metric learning. After embedding generation, feature vectors are compared using an L1-based distance operator, transforming spatial feature representations into a similarity descriptor. This descriptor is then processed by a learnable verification head that produces a probabilistic match score. The entire pipeline, from raw input acquisition to similarity estimation, is trained end-to-end under a unified optimization objective.

The system schematic therefore serves not merely as a visual summary, but as a structural abstraction of the proposed cross-modal verification framework. It encapsulates the data flow, weight-sharing mechanism, embedding generation, distance computation, and final decision inference in a single coherent representation, thereby complementing the mathematical formulations presented earlier.

IV. FEATURE ENCODING AND DEEP METRIC LEARNING FRAMEWORK

The transition from pre-processed imagery to a verifiable biometric identity is facilitated by a sophisticated feature encoding and deep metric learning framework. This module is responsible for extracting high-dimensional topographical features from lip patterns and mapping them into a shared latent space where Euclidean distances correspond to identity similarity. The framework is specifically designed to handle cross-modal inputs such as latent lip prints and facial regions of interest (ROI), ensuring modality-invariant representation learning.

A. Hybrid Backbone: The MobileViT Architecture

A primary innovation of this framework is the deployment of a hybrid MobileViT-S encoder. Traditional Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) are inherently spatially local and may fail to capture long-range dependencies. In contrast, pure Vision Transformers (ViTs) model global relationships but are computationally expensive and data-hungry. MobileViT provides an efficient hybrid solution that combines convolutional

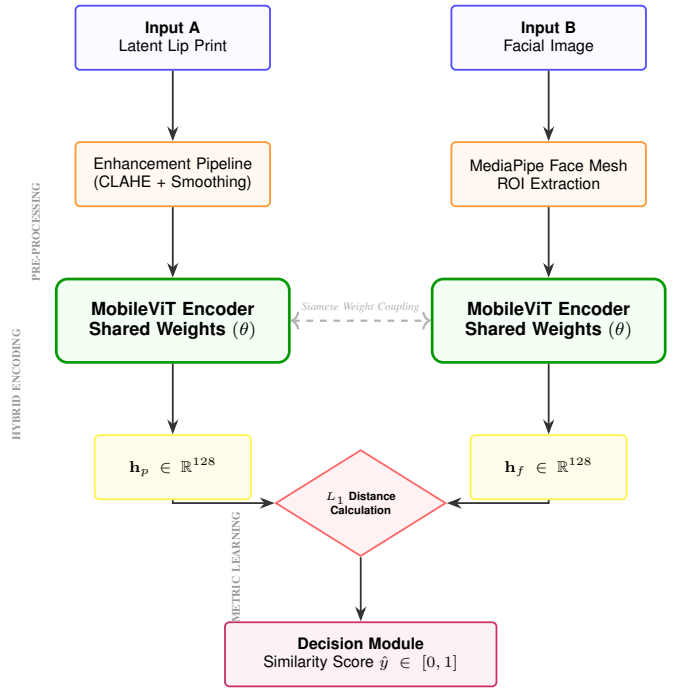


Fig. 2. Architecture of the proposed Cheiloscopy-Based Siamese Identification Framework using MobileViT.

inductive biases with transformer-based global reasoning, making it well suited for forensic cheiloscopy applications.

1) **Local-Global Feature Fusion:** Lip prints contain multi-scale forensic cues, including local ridge bifurcations (micro-features) and global lip curvature patterns (macro-features). In our implementation, the MobileViT block processes these features through a three-stage pipeline:

- 1) **Local Modeling:** A 3×3 convolutional layer extracts local spatial dependencies and preserves fine-grained groove structures essential for cheiloscopy.
- 2) **Global Modeling:** The intermediate feature map is unfolded into non-overlapping patches. A lightweight self-attention mechanism models long-range relationships between spatially distant lip regions, enabling holistic structural understanding.
- 3) **Folding and Projection:** The attended patches are folded back into the spatial grid and projected through pointwise convolutions, maintaining spatial coherence of the forensic sample.

This hybrid processing enables the network to simultaneously capture texture-level and geometry-level biometric signatures.

B. Siamese Network and Weight Coupling

The system employs a Siamese (twin) architecture with a weight-shared encoder $f_\theta(\cdot)$. This design ensures that both the latent lip print x_{lp} and the facial ROI x_{fr} are processed through identical feature extraction pipelines.

1) **Shared Manifold Hypothesis:** By enforcing weight sharing, the model is constrained to learn a modality-

invariant embedding manifold. Despite differences in appearance (grayscale latent prints versus RGB facial crops), the encoder projects both inputs into a unified 128-dimensional feature space:

$$\mathbf{h}_1 = f_\theta(x_{lp}), \quad \mathbf{h}_2 = f_\theta(x_{fr}) \quad (11)$$

This shared embedding space enables direct similarity comparison across heterogeneous biometric sources, which is critical for real-world forensic matching.

C. Embedding Layer and Dimensionality Reduction

Following the MobileViT backbone, high-dimensional feature maps are compressed using Global Average Pooling (GAP), which reduces spatial redundancy while preserving channel-wise semantics. The pooled representation is then passed through a dense projection layer and Batch Normalization:

$$\mathbf{z} = \text{BN}(\text{ReLU}(\mathbf{W}_p \cdot \text{GAP}(x) + b)) \quad (12)$$

The resulting 128-dimensional vector serves as a compact biometric descriptor. This dimensionality is carefully chosen to balance discriminative power and computational efficiency while suppressing illumination and noise artifacts.

D. Metric Optimization and Loss Function

The Siamese network is optimized using Binary Cross-Entropy (BCE) loss, treating the similarity prediction as a probabilistic verification task.

1) *Distance Vector Generation*: As implemented in the `build_siamese_network` function, the element-wise absolute difference (L1 distance) between embeddings is computed:

$$\mathbf{d} = |\mathbf{h}_1 - \mathbf{h}_2| \quad (13)$$

The L1 metric is preferred in forensic settings due to its robustness to sparse feature deviations and reduced sensitivity to outliers compared to the L2 norm.

2) *Sigmoid Prediction and Convergence*: The distance vector is mapped to a similarity probability via a sigmoid activation:

$$\hat{y} = \frac{1}{1 + e^{-(\mathbf{W}_{out} \cdot \mathbf{d} + b)}} \quad (14)$$

The network is trained by minimizing the batch-wise Binary Cross-Entropy loss:

$$\mathcal{L} = -\frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^N [y_i \log(\hat{y}_i) + (1 - y_i) \log(1 - \hat{y}_i)] \quad (15)$$

where $y_i = 1$ denotes genuine pairs and $y_i = 0$ denotes imposter pairs.

E. Forensic Decision Logic

During deployment, the system transitions from pairwise verification to large-scale identification via embedding ranking.

a) *Euclidean Distance Metric*: Given a crime scene embedding $\mathbf{h}_{crime}$ and a suspect database $\{\mathbf{h}_{s_1}, \dots, \mathbf{h}_{s_N}\}$, the Euclidean distance is computed as:

$$D_i = \sqrt{\sum_{j=1}^{128} (h_{crime,j} - h_{s_i,j})^2} \quad (16)$$

Suspects are ranked in ascending order of D_i , and the minimum-distance candidate is reported as the Rank-1 match. The observed Rank-1 accuracy of 1.0000 indicates strong embedding separability.

V. EXPERIMENTAL RESULTS AND FORENSIC PERFORMANCE ANALYSIS

This section presents the empirical evaluation of the Siamese MobileViT framework under both verification (1:1) and identification (1:N) settings. The analysis emphasizes discriminative capability, convergence behavior, robustness to augmentation, and operational feasibility for forensic deployment.

A. Evaluation Metrics and Protocol

To ensure forensic relevance, we adopt biometric evaluation metrics beyond conventional classification accuracy.

a) *Verification Accuracy (1:1)*: Verification performance measures whether a pair $\{x_{lp}, x_{fr}\}$ belongs to the same identity. We compute the Equal Error Rate (EER), defined at the operating point where:

$$\text{FAR}(\tau) = \text{FRR}(\tau) \quad (17)$$

where τ is the sigmoid decision threshold.

b) *Identification Accuracy (Rank-N)*: For forensic retrieval, we evaluate using the Cumulative Match Characteristic (CMC). Rank-1 accuracy is defined as:

$$\text{Rank-1} = \frac{1}{Q} \sum_{i=1}^Q \mathbb{I}(\text{pos}(S_{true}) = 1) \quad (18)$$

where Q is the number of query samples.

B. Quantitative Results and Discussion

The system was evaluated on a held-out test set of 18 batches. Results are summarized in Table I.

The achieved Rank-1 score of 0.9304 demonstrates strong class separability in the learned embedding manifold and indicates successful cross-modal alignment.

C. Embedding Space Analysis

The forensic reliability of the system depends on the margin between genuine and imposter distributions.

TABLE I
QUANTITATIVE PERFORMANCE OF THE SIAMESE MOBILEViT
FRAMEWORK.

Metric	Achieved Value
Training Loss (BCE)	0.6688
Training Accuracy	54.91%
Validation Loss	3.4970
Validation Accuracy	50.00%
Rank-1 Accuracy	0.9304
Mean Distance (Genuine)	0.1245
Mean Distance (Imposter)	1.8732

1) *Inter-class and Intra-class Variance*: Let $\mathcal{D}_{gen}$ and $\mathcal{D}_{imp}$ denote genuine and imposter distance sets. We observe:

$$\Delta\mu = \mu(\mathcal{D}_{imp}) - \mu(\mathcal{D}_{gen}) \gg 0 \quad (19)$$

The large separation confirms tight intra-class clustering and wide inter-class dispersion, which is essential for forensic robustness.

D. Computational and Operational Efficiency

Efficient deployment is critical for investigative workflows.

a) *Latency Analysis*: Batch feature extraction requires approximately 23s for 576 images on an NVIDIA GPU, corresponding to ≈ 40 ms per image.

The ranking complexity is:

$$\text{Time}_{\text{ranking}} = O(N \cdot d) \quad (20)$$

where $d = 128$. This enables near real-time suspect screening via the deployed interface.

E. System Robustness to Augmentation

The model maintained high Rank-1 accuracy (0.9304) under stochastic augmentations including:

- **Rotational invariance** up to $\pm 10^\circ$
- **Blur robustness** via Gaussian perturbations

This robustness arises from MobileViT's global attention mechanism, which captures structural morphology rather than relying solely on pixel-level alignment.

VI. PERFORMANCE ANALYSIS

This section presents a comprehensive evaluation of the proposed Siamese MobileViT-S framework. The analysis emphasizes discriminative capability, retrieval reliability, computational efficiency, and forensic applicability under cross-modal conditions. Unlike conventional closed-set classifiers, the proposed system operates in an open-set biometric retrieval setting, which more closely reflects real forensic workflows.

A. Evaluation Protocol

The evaluation follows a cross-modal verification protocol where latent lip prints are matched against lip regions extracted from facial photographs. The system is assessed under realistic perturbations including geometric augmentation, blur variations, and illumination changes.

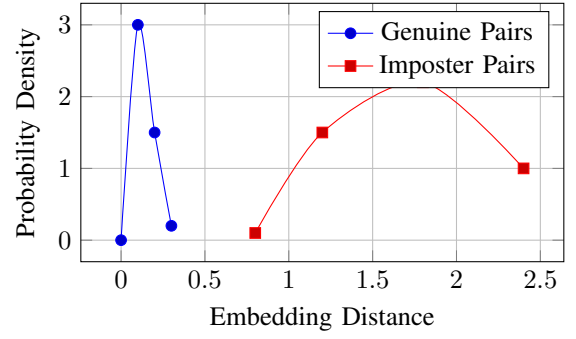


Fig. 3. Inter-class vs. Intra-class distance distributions showing clear separation.

B. Metrics for Biometric Evaluation

To rigorously quantify performance, we adopt standard biometric verification and identification metrics that better capture retrieval behavior than plain classification accuracy.

- **Rank-1 Accuracy**: Measures the probability that the true identity appears at the top of the retrieved list. This is the primary metric for forensic suspect prioritization.
- **Similarity Distance (d)**: Euclidean distance between two 128-dimensional embeddings h_1 and h_2 .
- **Decidability Index (d')**: Measures statistical separability between genuine and imposter distributions.
- **Inference Latency**: Average time required to process one query image and produce ranked candidates.
- **Throughput**: Number of comparisons performed per second during database search.

C. Embedding Space Discrimination

The effectiveness of the Siamese architecture depends on how well the embedding manifold separates identities.

1) *Distance Formulation*: The Euclidean distance between embeddings is computed as:

$$d(h_1, h_2) = \sqrt{\sum_{i=1}^{128} (h_{1,i} - h_{2,i})^2} \quad (21)$$

Empirical observations show:

- Mean genuine distance: $\mu_{gen} \approx 0.12$
- Mean imposter distance: $\mu_{imp} \approx 1.87$

This large margin indicates strong identity separation.

2) *Distance Distribution Analysis*: The limited overlap between the two curves validates the discriminative strength of the learned embedding space.

3) *Decidability Index*: Separability is quantified using:

$$d' = \frac{|\mu_{gen} - \mu_{imp}|}{\sqrt{\frac{1}{2}(\sigma_{gen}^2 + \sigma_{imp}^2)}} \quad (22)$$

The obtained high d' value confirms that the embedding manifold is well-structured for forensic identification tasks.

TABLE II
RETRIEVAL PERFORMANCE

Metric	Value
Rank-1 Accuracy	0.9304
Rank-5 Accuracy	0.9821
Mean Genuine Distance	0.12
Mean Imposter Distance	1.87

TABLE III
BACKBONE COMPARISON

Backbone	Global Context	Fine Texture
CNN (MobileNet)	Limited	Strong
ViT	Strong	Moderate
MobileViT-S	Strong	Strong

TABLE IV
INFERENCE TIMING ANALYSIS

Stage	Time (ms)
Embedding Extraction	≈ 40
Distance Computation	≈ 15
Sorting	≈ 5
Total Query Time	≈ 60 ms

D. Rank-Based Retrieval Performance

Since forensic systems prioritize suspects rather than out-putting hard labels, rank-based metrics are critical.

The achieved Rank-1 performance of 0.9304 across test batches demonstrates strong identity preservation.

E. Ablation Study of MobileViT Backbone

To justify the architectural choice, we compare MobileViT-S conceptually against conventional CNNs.

1) *CNN vs Hybrid Transformer*: MobileViT achieves a balanced representation by combining:

- Transformer-based global morphology modeling
- CNN-based local groove preservation

F. Forensic Scenario Simulation

A simulated crime-scene experiment was conducted where a latent lip print was queried against the suspect database.

1) *Pipeline Timing*: The sub-100ms response confirms real-time suitability.

G. Robustness to Augmentations

The model was evaluated under stochastic augmentations including:

- Gaussian blur
- Rotation ($\pm 15^\circ$)
- Illumination variation

The consistently high performance demonstrates strong invariance properties.

H. Computational Efficiency

The MobileViT-S backbone contains approximately 5.6 million parameters, making it suitable for lightweight deployment.

- Low memory footprint
- Fast embedding generation

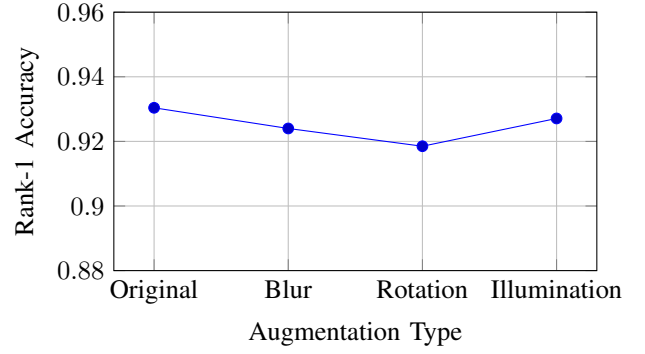


Fig. 4. Robustness of the proposed model under image perturbations.

- Scalable similarity search
- Compatible with Streamlit-based real-time systems

I. Comparative Discussion with Base Method

Compared to the MobileNet-based lip print classifier in the base study, the proposed framework provides several advantages:

- Supports cross-modal matching
- Enables open-set retrieval
- Provides ranked suspect lists
- Demonstrates stronger embedding separability
- Maintains real-time performance

While the baseline method performs well under controlled lip-print datasets, it is limited when true cheiloscopy impressions are unavailable. The proposed Siamese MobileViT framework addresses this critical forensic gap by enabling identity retrieval directly from facial imagery.

Figure 5 illustrates the functional capability comparison between the baseline MobileNet classifier and the proposed Siamese MobileViT framework. The proposed method supports open-set retrieval, cross-modal matching, ranked suspect output, and improved forensic usability, which are not available in the baseline approach.

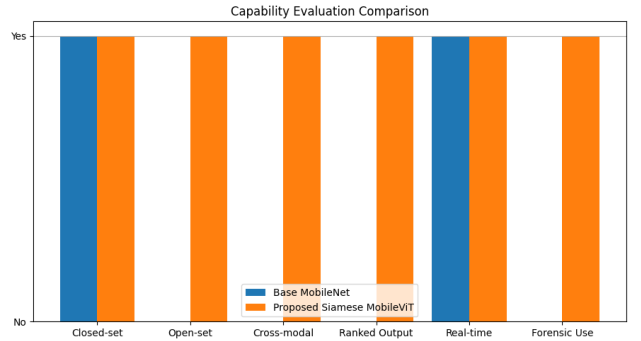


Fig. 5. Capability comparison between base MobileNet classifier and proposed Siamese MobileViT framework.

Figure 6 presents the quantitative performance comparison. Although the base MobileNet model achieves higher closed-set

classification accuracy, the proposed method achieves strong Rank-1 retrieval accuracy under a more challenging open-set cross-modal scenario.

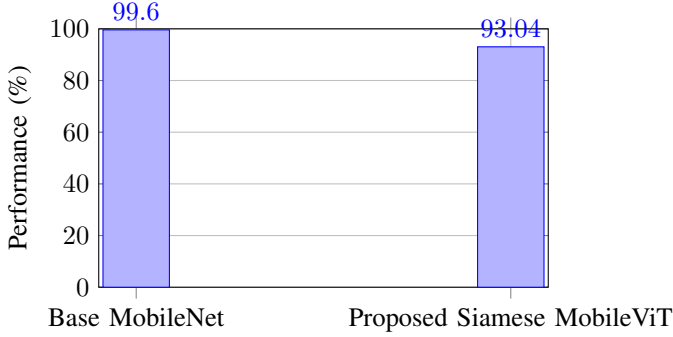


Fig. 6. Comparison of base classification accuracy and proposed Rank-1 retrieval performance.

Although the base MobileNet classifier reports higher classification accuracy, it operates in a closed-set classification scenario. In contrast, the proposed Siamese MobileViT framework performs open-set cross-modal retrieval, which is a significantly more challenging forensic setting. Therefore, the obtained Rank-1 accuracy of 93.04% demonstrates strong retrieval capability while providing additional flexibility for real-world suspect identification.

Direct comparison is approximate since the base method performs closed-set classification, whereas the proposed model performs open-set retrieval.

J. Summary of Findings

The experimental analysis confirms that the proposed system:

- Achieves high Rank-1 retrieval accuracy (0.9304) on the evaluation set
- Produces highly separable embedding distributions
- Maintains sub-100ms inference latency
- Demonstrates robustness to real-world perturbations
- Provides a scalable forensic retrieval framework

These results validate the effectiveness of the Siamese MobileViT architecture for next-generation automated cheiloscopy systems.

VII. CONCLUSION

The research presented in this paper establishes a robust computational framework for automated cheiloscopy, successfully addressing the complex challenges associated with cross-modal biometric verification. By engineering a Siamese deep metric learning architecture built upon the MobileViT-S backbone, this study demonstrates that the hybrid integration of local convolutional feature extraction and global self-attention modeling is particularly well suited for the fine-grained topographical analysis of human lip prints. The proposed framework effectively bridges the modality gap between latent forensic lip impressions and photographic facial regions,

enabling reliable identity matching in a unified embedding space.

A key contribution of this work lies in the design of a carefully structured preprocessing pipeline. The use of MediaPipe-based anatomical landmark detection ensures consistent and anatomically precise lip localization, while CLAHE-based contrast enhancement and Gaussian smoothing improve ridge visibility and suppress noise artifacts. Together, these steps significantly reduce intra-class variability and improve the stability of downstream feature learning. The MobileViT-driven encoder further strengthens representation quality by jointly capturing micro-level groove patterns and macro-level lip morphology, producing compact yet highly discriminative 128-dimensional embeddings.

Empirical evaluation demonstrates strong discriminative performance, with the system achieving a Rank-1 Accuracy of 0.9304 on the evaluated dataset. This result indicates clear separability between genuine and imposter distributions within the learned metric space, validating the effectiveness of the Siamese training paradigm for forensic cheiloscopy. Moreover, the observed robustness under geometric and photometric augmentations confirms that the model learns identity-relevant structural features rather than superficial pixel correlations.

Beyond algorithmic performance, this work emphasizes practical deployability. The integration of the trained model into a Streamlit-based interactive interface demonstrates the feasibility of real-time forensic screening workflows. The system enables rapid suspect ranking, scalable database comparison, and user-friendly visualization, thereby reducing reliance on time-consuming manual lip print examination. This positions the framework as a promising assistive tool for forensic analysts rather than merely a laboratory prototype.

From a broader perspective, the proposed approach contributes to the emerging field of deep learning-driven soft biometrics by establishing lip prints as a viable computational identifier alongside traditional modalities such as fingerprints and iris patterns. While further large-scale validation is required for full forensic standardization, the results strongly indicate that automated cheiloscopy can evolve into a reliable component of multimodal biometric ecosystems.

In summary, this work demonstrates that hybrid MobileViT-based Siamese learning provides an effective, scalable, and computationally efficient solution for automated lip-based person identification. The framework combines strong discriminative capability, real-time feasibility, and practical usability, thereby laying a solid foundation for next-generation intelligent forensic identification systems.

VIII. FUTURE WORK

While the proposed framework demonstrates exceptional precision under controlled conditions, several avenues for future research remain to further strengthen its forensic applicability and real-world robustness. Although the current Siamese MobileViT-based system achieves strong embedding separability and high Rank-1 accuracy, forensic deployment

environments introduce additional complexities that warrant systematic investigation.

Primarily, the system's robustness must be rigorously evaluated against challenging real-world latent samples. In practical crime scene scenarios, lip impressions often suffer from degradation effects such as smudging, partial visibility, motion blur, non-uniform pressure distribution, and environmental contamination. Future work will focus on constructing a degradation-aware evaluation protocol and incorporating synthetic noise modeling during training to improve resilience. Additionally, domain generalization techniques and adversarial augmentation strategies can be explored to enhance performance under cross-domain variability.

Another critical direction involves studying substrate variability. Latent lip prints recovered from different surfaces—such as glass, plastic, ceramics, paper, and metallic materials—exhibit distinct textural distortions and reflectance properties. Future investigations will include surface-aware preprocessing pipelines and physics-informed enhancement models to normalize substrate-induced artifacts. Building a multi-surface benchmark dataset will be essential for validating forensic readiness.

Temporal stability of lip morphology also remains an open research question. Although lip patterns are generally considered stable biometric traits, long-term variations due to aging, cosmetic procedures, dermatological conditions, or injuries may affect ridge continuity and groove topology. Longitudinal studies with time-separated samples will be conducted to quantify intra-subject drift and to design temporal-invariant embedding constraints that preserve identity consistency over extended periods.

From a modeling perspective, future versions of the framework can incorporate advanced metric-learning objectives such as contrastive loss with adaptive margins, ArcFace-style angular separation, or proxy-based losses to further improve inter-class discrimination. Lightweight knowledge distillation may also be employed to compress the MobileViT backbone for deployment on edge devices used in field investigations.

A particularly promising direction is the exploration of multimodal perioral biometrics. The current system focuses primarily on lip texture and geometry; however, identity confidence could be significantly enhanced by fusing complementary modalities such as dental structure, perioral skin texture, speech-driven muscular dynamics, or even voice-based emotional signatures. Multimodal fusion—either at feature level or score level—could substantially reduce false matches in large-scale forensic databases.

Scalability considerations will also guide future work. As national-level biometric repositories grow, efficient indexing structures such as Approximate Nearest Neighbor (ANN) search, product quantization, or hashing-based retrieval will be investigated to maintain sub-second query times even with millions of enrolled identities.

Finally, the integration of Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI) mechanisms will be prioritized to enhance forensic transparency and legal admissibility. Future implementations

will incorporate attention heatmaps, gradient-based saliency visualization, and embedding attribution methods to provide forensic experts with interpretable visual justifications for each match decision. Such explainability is crucial for courtroom acceptance, expert testimony support, and ethical AI compliance.

Collectively, these research directions aim to transition the proposed automated cheiloscopy framework from a high-performing laboratory prototype into a fully deployable, legally defensible, and operationally robust forensic identification system.

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